

Business Plan



Students Digital Marketplace

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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Student mobility is growing rapidly, with thousands relocating each year for exchange programs, degree progression, and international studies. Despite the opportunity this creates, one problem remains consistent: finding reliable and affordable housing in an unfamiliar city.

Students currently rely on scattered social media groups and generic rental platforms that are not built specifically for them. These channels lack proper verification and expose students to misinformation, scams, and unnecessary stress during an already demanding academic transition.

This platform introduces a verified, student-only digital marketplace focused on trusted accommodation. Access is restricted to university email accounts, and listings are reviewed to create a secure, student-centered environment.

Beyond housing, the same platform includes a student essentials marketplace, enabling peer-to-peer exchange of furniture, study materials, and household items. By combining verified housing with community-driven exchange, the platform reduces cost, increases trust, and creates a shared ecosystem for students navigating relocation.

The goal is simple: remove friction from student mobility and replace uncertainty with a structured, trusted solution.

DEFINING THE PROBLEM

Starting with the scale of the issue: across the European Union alone, approximately 1.5 million young people participated in Erasmus+ mobility activities in 2024 (European Commission, 2024) . When combined with students relocating for full-degree programs, faculty transfers, master's studies, and other academic progression paths, student relocation becomes a large-scale and recurring phenomenon within modern education. Mobility creates opportunity — exposure to new cultures, expanded networks, and academic growth. However, it also introduces structural challenges, particularly in securing stable and reliable accommodation in unfamiliar environments.

The primary problems students encounter include:

- Inability to verify accommodation listings — students cannot easily confirm authenticity or safety
- Exposure to scams and misleading offers — especially in unknown rental markets
- Limited access to student-specific housing options — generic platforms are not designed around student realities
- Absence of structured institutional support — students must independently navigate fragmented information
- Ineffective social verification — informal networks often circulate incomplete or inaccurate details

Students are expected to make high-stakes housing decisions with limited local knowledge, tight budgets, and strict academic timelines. While global booking platforms exist, they do not address the verification gap or the specific pressures associated with student relocation.

The issue is not the absence of rental platforms. It is the absence of infrastructure built exclusively for the student experience — one that combines trust, relevance, and community within a structured and accountable environment.

SOLUTION

The solution is a centralized, university-verified digital marketplace designed exclusively for students. The platform operates as a structured ecosystem with two integrated modules:

1. **Student Marketplace Module (A Peer-to-Peer Economy)**

This section enables students to buy and sell second-hand items within a trusted academic environment. It supports:

- Furniture
- Electronics
- Study materials
- Household items
- Short-term relocation goods

Access to the platform is restricted to verified university email addresses, ensuring a trusted and secure environment for students. Each user has a transparent profile with activity history, creating accountability within the system. A simple reputation system will be implemented, allowing users to rate completed transactions based on their experience. This builds a trust score over time and encourages responsible behavior. An integrated messaging system enables direct communication between peers, allowing clear negotiation and coordination inside a secure environment.

The goal is to create a structured student marketplace where trust, transparency, and accessibility drive participation. Hence, we attract the audience the play is made for. If we offer what students seek to have, they'll offer it too. We are just here to provide the services they need to solve the problems that have arisen.

2. Verified Housing & Communication Module

This module focuses on accommodation.

It includes:

- Manual verification of rental listings
- Identity verification of landlords
- Structured listing requirements (photos, documents, pricing transparency)
- Secure in-platform communication
- Controlled interaction environment
- Institutional collaboration where possible

The platform operates as a structured trust layer between students and landlords. Instead of relying on fragmented external communication channels, all interactions, negotiations, and agreements take place within a monitored and standardized system designed to reduce fraud, misinformation, and uncertainty. Landlords who wish to list properties for student tenants must follow a defined onboarding protocol. This includes identity verification, compliance with listing standards, and approval before publication. Listings must meet structured requirements to ensure transparency, consistency, and reliability. The system does not function as an open posting board. Content is regulated to maintain quality, accuracy, and relevance. This controlled environment ensures that both parties operate within clear guidelines, promoting accountability and trust.

For students, the platform provides access to verified accommodations with standardized descriptions, structured data, and secure in-platform communication.

The platform does not replace existing rental services. Instead, it introduces a specialized infrastructure tailored exclusively to the student community — offering a secure, identity-based environment that bridges the gap between academic mobility and housing reliability.

MARKETING AND SALES PLAN

As we rely solely on students as the target audience for our business, we need to align with their schedules, deadlines, and activities. Nowadays, their attention is primarily on social media, so that is one of our focuses. Besides social media, since we offer services to students starting their college life when relocation is necessary, that is when we will be most active and recognizable. How do we achieve this?

1. University-Based Distribution Model

The primary growth channel is institutional collaboration with universities.

When students are accepted (Erasmus+, full-degree, exchange, relocation), the platform link can be distributed through:

- Official faculty communication emails
- Admission confirmation packages
- International student offices
- Orientation materials
- Student support departments

This ensures direct access to students at the exact moment they need accommodation and relocation support. By integrating into the onboarding process, the platform positions itself as infrastructure rather than optional software. It is our obligation to follow the universities' rules, deadlines, and ways of operating. When we succeed in synchronizing with the same needs as the students, we can be at the right place at the right time, collectively gather our target audience, achieve our goals, and provide a solution for their ongoing problems.

2. Early-Stage Student Acquisition

The highest conversion window is before arrival, when students:

- Have urgency
- Have allocated relocation budgets
- Need reliable housing

At this stage, a small one-time registration fee or low monthly subscription is more acceptable, as the service directly reduces housing risk.

Pricing can be positioned as:

- Basic access (free or low-cost)
- Premium access (priority listings, boosted visibility, early access, etc.)

3. Strategic Student Organization Partnerships

Student organizations and relocation support groups can:

- Promote the platform to incoming students
- Receive promotional placement on the platform
- Offer verified listings
- Partner in exchange for visibility

This creates a mutually reinforcing ecosystem.

PRODUCT DESCRIPTION

The platform is a verified, student-only digital marketplace designed to support student relocation. It combines:

- A curated accommodation marketplace.
- A student essentials exchange (furniture, study materials, household items).
- A secure, university-verified communication environment.

It is not a generic rental website. It is infrastructure built specifically around the student mobility lifecycle.

The system works with the following features and specifications:

1. Access & Verification

- Users register exclusively through their verified university email address, which they must confirm when creating an account.
- Identity validation ensures that all the users of the system are students.

2. Housing Listings

- Landlords submit the accommodation listings with required documentation and standardized templates, following rules and guidelines.
- Every listing goes through a review to check if it satisfies all requirements.
- Students have the option to filter through the listings by city, price range, and other criteria.
- Communication can be established between a student and a landlord via integrated messaging system when a listing is selected.

3. Student Essentials Marketplace

- Students can post their items for sale.
 - Listings are tied to the verified student's account.
 - An essential description for the posted item must be entered, including images, price, and location.
 - Communication for the transaction between the two peers can be established by creating a chat.
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SWOT ANALYSIS

Strengths

- Clear target market
- Dual Marketplace Structure
- User Satisfaction
- Scalable Digital Model

Weaknesses

- Network Dependency
- Early-Stage Traction
- Landlord Adoption Barrier
- Revenue Timing

Opportunities

- Growing Student Mobility
- University Partnerships
- Expansion Beyond Housing
- Community Monetization

Threats

- Large Platform Replication
- Fraud Attempts Within Verification System
- Slow Institutional Adoption

COMPETITIVE POSITIONING

The proposed platform operates within a digital environment currently dominated by a mix of general online marketplaces and specialized housing platforms. While these services provide partial solutions, none are designed specifically around a verified student-only ecosystem, which creates a gap in the market.

Facebook Marketplace

Facebook Marketplace is one of the largest peer-to-peer digital marketplaces in the world. Its accessibility and integration with social media have made it a popular option for students searching for accommodation or second-hand goods.

According to marketplace research and usage reports:

- Facebook Marketplace facilitates over 3 billion buyer–seller connections each month.
- The platform receives more than 800 million monthly visits, with users spending an average of around 20 minutes per session browsing listings.
- Approximately 16% of Facebook users access the platform specifically to browse Marketplace listings.

Despite its scale and accessibility, several studies highlight significant limitations related to safety and reliability:

- Around 62% of users report encountering scams or fraudulent listings while using Facebook Marketplace.
- Financial losses from Marketplace fraud have reached tens of millions annually in certain countries, highlighting the vulnerability of users in unverified environments.

These statistics demonstrate that while Facebook Marketplace offers a large audience and ease of access, it lacks essential mechanisms such as identity verification, structured listing systems, and student-specific protections. As a result, trust depends largely on informal interactions between individuals.

Uniplaces

Uniplaces represents a more specialized approach by focusing specifically on student housing.

The platform connects students with landlords and provides structured accommodation listings in major European cities. Early platform data indicates that:

- Uniplaces initially listed more than 20,000 rooms across cities such as London, Madrid, and Lisbon.
- The platform has generated millions of euros in bookings for landlords through student rentals.
- Some listings are marked with verification badges after property inspection by the platform.

Although Uniplaces improves reliability compared to general marketplaces, its primary function remains that of a property booking intermediary. The platform focuses on landlord-to-student transactions and does not incorporate a broader student ecosystem.

Specifically, it does not provide:

- peer-to-peer student marketplaces for everyday goods
- community-based interaction between verified students
- integrated relocation support features

Competitive Opportunity

Both platforms demonstrate that there is strong demand for digital tools that facilitate student relocation. However, they also illustrate a structural gap.

General marketplaces provide scale but lack verification and safety mechanisms, while housing platforms offer structured listings but do not support broader student community interaction.

The proposed platform positions itself within this gap by combining three key elements:

- Verified student-only access through university email authentication.
- A structured housing marketplace designed for student accommodation.
- A peer-to-peer exchange marketplace for student essentials

By integrating these functions within a single environment, the platform aims to create a trusted digital infrastructure tailored specifically to student mobility.

Rather than acting solely as a listing service, the platform focuses on building a verified ecosystem where students can secure housing, exchange essential goods, and interact within a community of individuals facing similar relocation challenges.

MARKET SIZE ANALYSIS

To understand the potential of the business, it is essential to analyze the market size using the TAM, SAM, and SOM framework. This provides a structured answer to the fundamental questions:

How many potential customers exist, and how large could this business become?

Total Addressable Market (TAM)

TAM represents the total possible demand if the platform captured the entire market. Research estimates that the European student accommodation market could reach approximately \$27.5 billion by 2031, growing at an annual rate close to 9–10%.

This market includes:

- International students
- Domestic students relocating to other cities
- Exchange students
- Postgraduate students

Every year, millions of students relocate across Europe for academic purposes, creating a large and recurring demand for accommodation and relocation services.

Serviceable Available Market (SAM)

SAM represents the portion of the total market that the platform can realistically serve based on its focus. We specifically target:

- Students relocating within Europe
- University-verified users
- Short-to-medium term student housing
- Peer-to-peer student marketplaces

For example:

- Around 1.5 million students participated in Erasmus+ mobility programs in 2024 [Source: European Commission, 2024].
- Millions more relocate domestically for university studies.
- This creates a large addressable user base within universities and student mobility networks.

Serviceable Obtainable Market (SOM)

SOM represents the realistic share that it could capture during its early growth phase. For example, an initial expansion strategy may focus on:

- One or two university cities.
- Several thousand students.
- Limited verified housing listings.

A realistic early scenario could be:

- 5,000 – 10,000 users in the first operational markets.
- Hundreds of active housing listings.
- A growing student marketplace community.

As the platform expands to additional universities and countries, the obtainable market grows significantly.

REVENUE AND GROWTH

Revenue Stream	Price Model	Assumptions
Student Registration	€5 one-time	5,000 students
Premium Subscription	€5/month	10% users
Featured Listings	€10 per listing	200 listings/month

Marketing Funnel

1. Awareness

- TikTok/Instagram Student Content
- Erasmus Groups
- Influencer Partnerships

2. Acquisition

- University Email onboarding
- Referral System

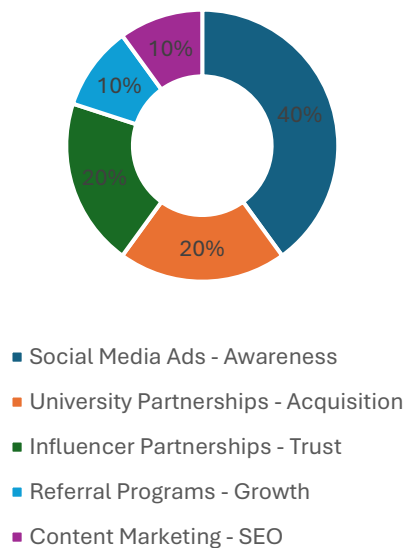
3. Conversion

- Urgency-driven messaging
- First listing / buy will be Free

4. Retention

- In-App Messaging
- Reputation (Review) System

Marketing Budget Allocation



Growth Model

Month	Users	Revenue (€)	Status
1-3	1,000	1,000-2,000	Loss
4-6	5,000	5,000-7,000	Break-even
6-12	15,000	10,000+	Profit

BREAK-EVEN ANALYSIS

Given that we are primarily launching the business as a digital marketplace, most of the early costs will be dedicated to development, maintenance, and marketing, with revenue growing in line with user activity and listings.

For an early-stage digital marketplace built by us using cloud infrastructure like Amazon Web Services (AWS) or Microsoft Azure, the operational costs are significantly lower than traditional startup estimates, and this is an advantage we intend to leverage.

Cost Category	Estimated Annual Cost
Domain, Security & Services	€100- €300
Cloud hosting & Infrastructure	€1,000- €2,000
Development & Maintenance	€2,000 - €3,000
Customer Support & Moderation	€5,000
Digital Marketing & Promotion	€3,000- €5,000
Additional Tools & Automation	€500
Total Estimation Cost	~€15.000

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[STATISTIC/SOURCE] : European Commission, 2024 (for Erasmus+ participation)

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[STATISTIC/SOURCE] : Uniplaces early platform data

[STATISTIC/SOURCE] : European student accommodation market value projection (\$27.5 billion by 2031)
